Weekly Bulletin of IT News and Articles

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CIS NEWS

1. Vučić in Astana: trade, defense, and technology drive Kazakhstan–Serbia talks

(The Times of Central Asia)

On February 26, 2026, Serbian President **Aleksandar Vučić** arrived in Astana, Kazakhstan, for a two-day official visit to hold talks with President **Kassym-Jomart Tokayev**. The visit, which builds on momentum from **Tokayev's** late-2024 trip to Serbia, centers on expanding political dialogue, digital transformation, and economic ties, with bilateral trade having grown by over 7% to approximately $ 117 million in 2025. During the trip, the two nations are expected to adopt a joint statement and sign ten memorandums.

Significant agreements were reached in the defense sector, including cooperation between Kazakhstan's LLP SP Kaztechnology and Serbia's Yugoimport SDPR on repairing and modernizing 122mm and 152mm self-propelled artillery systems, alongside a framework agreement for technology transfer in high-energy materials production. Additionally, partnerships were forged in technology and science, highlighted by memorandums between Astana Hub and Serbian tech accelerators, as well as between Kazakhstan's National Biotechnology Center and Serbia's Bio4 Campus.

President **Vučić's** visit marks a strategic and practical deepening of relations between the Balkans and Central Asia. While overall trade volume remains relatively modest, the shift toward concrete, high-value collaborations in defense manufacturing, digital innovation, and biotechnology signals that Serbia and Kazakhstan are successfully transitioning their relationship from basic diplomatic engagement into a robust, specialized industrial partnership.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/vucic-in-astana-trade-defense-and-technology-drive-kazakhstan-serbia-talks/)

2. Kazakhstani officials visited the newly established Freedom IT-Hub in Dushanbe

(Astana Hub)

During a visit to Dushanbe, Kazakhstan's Minister of Foreign Affairs, **Yermek Kosherbayev**, toured the Freedom IT-Hub, a joint technological platform established on the basis of Freedom Bank Tajikistan and curated by Kazakhstan's international innovation cluster, Astana Hub. As part of the visit, local startups presented their innovative projects, and Freedom Bank Tajikistan signed a Memorandum of Understanding with IT Park Dushanbe to jointly support youth tech

education and entrepreneurial initiatives. Operating fully since autumn 2025, the Freedom IT-Hub was created to develop digital competencies and support tech entrepreneurship in Tajikistan; it has already hosted over 80 events for 2,000 participants, including AI bootcamps and data analytics hackathons.

The initiative demonstrates Kazakhstan's strategic push to export its successful digital ecosystem model across borders. By combining private financial capital *(Freedom Bank)* with state-backed innovation frameworks *(Astana Hub)*, Kazakhstan is actively investing in Tajikistan's IT infrastructure and human capital. This approach not only deepens bilateral tech diplomacy but also solidifies Kazakhstan's position as the leading technological anchor and hub for the broader Central Asian region.

(Read full article at https://astanahub.com/en/article/freedom-it-hub-usilivaet-tsifrovoe-partniorstvo-kazakhstana-i-tadzhikistana)

3. Kazakhstan advances 1 GW data center valley project in Ekibastuz

(The Astana Times)

Kazakhstan is moving forward with the large-scale Data Center Valley project in Ekibastuz, the Pavlodar Region, aimed at creating the largest data center campus in Central Asia with an energy capacity of up to 1 gigawatt. The progress of the initiative was reviewed at a Feb 25 government meeting chaired by Prime Minister **Olzhas Bektenov**.

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Artificial Intelligence and Digital Development **Zhaslan Madiyev**, along with Chairman of the Board of Kazakhtelecom **Bagdat Mussin**, reported on the work carried out since the project's launch in January in Pavlodar Region.

The Data Center Valley project aims to establish the largest data center campus in Central Asia, with a planned energy capacity of up to 1 gigawatt. The initiative is in an active implementation phase, with the government ensuring the necessary infrastructure and legal framework.

To date, land plots totaling 1,400 hectares have been allocated. Work is underway to acquire a substation to support the large-scale development, while additional state support mechanisms for investors and project participants are being developed.

A key element of the infrastructure will be a Greenfield zone designed to attract international partners. Initial capacity of up to 100 megawatts has been prepared, with the potential for further expansion.

The infrastructure will meet the Tier III international standard, with a Power Usage Effectiveness *(PUE)* ratio of 1.25. To meet the requirements of hyperscale and BigTech companies in telecommunications infrastructure, network latency is planned to be reduced from 80 milliseconds to 57 milliseconds, a level comparable to major European traffic exchange hubs.

This mega-project underscores Kazakhstan's strategic ambition to pivot from merely adopting digital technology to becoming the foundational data transit and storage hub for the Eurasian continent. By aggressively leveraging its vast land and energy resources to build high-efficiency, massive-scale infrastructure with European-grade latency, Kazakhstan is directly positioning itself to capture the rapidly growing, energy-intensive global market for AI training and BigTech data hosting, thereby securing long-term foreign technological investment.

(Read full article at https://astanatimes.com/2026/02/kazakhstan-advances-1-gw-data-center-valley-project-in-ekibastuz/)

4. Kazakhstan, EDB explore major investment projects and digital initiatives

(The Astana Times)

Kazakh Prime Minister Olzhas Bektenov met with Nikolai Podguzov, chair of the Management Board of the Eurasian Development Bank *(EDB)*, on Feb. 27 to discuss ongoing and upcoming investment projects in Kazakhstan and prospects for expansion of cooperation in key economic sectors.

The talks also emphasized digital transformation, renewable energy, and initiatives to strengthen the investment climate. Both officials noted opportunities for new projects in manufacturing, mining, telecommunications, and solar energy, including the construction of solar power plants in the Turkistan and Kyzylorda Regions, reported the bank's press service on Feb. 27.

Podguzov underscored the EDB's commitment to supporting Kazakhstan's sustainable economic growth and improving citizens' quality of life, while Bektenov stressed the importance of infrastructure development and the digital agenda as national priorities. The meeting concluded with a mutual commitment to deepen the constructive partnership and expand investment cooperation in the country's long-term economic interest.

Meeting highlights Kazakhstan's strategic reliance on regional **financial** institutions like the EDB to fund its capital-intensive modernization goals. By actively directing major investments toward high-tech infrastructure and green energy, rather than exclusively focusing on traditional fossil fuels, Kazakhstan is accelerating its transition into a diversified, sustainable, and digitally advanced economy.

(Read full article at https://astanatimes.com/2026/02/kazakhstan-edb-explore-major-investment-projects-and-digital-initiatives/)

5. Founder of inDrive sees kindred spirit in Olympic champion's father

(The Times of Central Asia)

Years ago, Stanislav Shaidorov, a former figure skating champion of Kazakhstan, sold his car to help pay for his son Mikhail's training on the ice. After Mikhail won Olympic gold

this month, the older Shaidorov was presented with an Audi Q8 by a businessman who had done the same thing for a different cause.

"This story is personal for me," said Arsen Tomsky, founder and CEO of the ride-hailing app inDrive, which operates in dozens of countries.

"I did the same twice in my life – once to pay salaries when my first company had no money, and once to send the Yakutia e-sports team to a national championship when we couldn't afford the tickets," Tomsky said on Instagram.

Yakutia is in Russia. Tomsky was born in Russia, moved many employees to Kazakhstan after Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022, and obtained Kazakhstani citizenship in 2023. Forbes Kazakhstan ranked Tomsky as the 11th richest business executive in the country in 2025…

Tomsky, the inDrive founder, said he could relate to Stanislav Shaidorov's decision to give up his car for his son's dream.

"In moments like that, you don't think about the car," the executive said. "You think about the future and the people you believe in."

Such gesture highlights a powerful intersection of sports, business, and personal sacrifice. By rewarding **Stanislav Shaidorov's** dedication, **Arsen Tomsky** not only celebrated Kazakhstan's monumental Olympic victory but also publicly validated the profound, often unseen financial and personal sacrifices that parents and early believers must make to cultivate world-class success, reflecting his own entrepreneurial journey.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/founder-of-indrive-sees-kindred-spirit-in-olympic-champions-father/)

6. Kyrgyz citizens to be allowed to pass on E-Wallet funds to heirs

(The Times of Central Asia)

Kyrgyzstan's parliament has approved a government initiative to regulate the inheritance of electronic money, aiming to amend the Civil Code to legally recognize e-wallet funds as part of a citizen's property. **The popularity of e-wallets in the country has surged, exceeding 6.5 million users** *(a 20% annual increase)* with over 132 million transactions recorded in the first half of the previous year. Previously, the lack of unified rules caused legal disputes, as commercial banks handled e-wallet inheritance independently, sometimes releasing funds to whichever heir contacted them first. Under the new draft amendments, banks will be required to block an e-wallet upon receiving a notary's notification of the owner's death, and funds will only be distributed after heirs' rights are formally verified according to the law.

The legislative reform marks a critical step in modernizing Kyrgyzstan's civil law to keep pace with the rapid digitalization of its financial sector. **By formally equating e-wallet funds with traditional bank accounts and establishing a uniform, notary-verified inheritance procedure, the government is closing a significant regulatory loophole, thereby ensuring legal clarity**, protecting citizens' digital assets, and reducing the risk of inheritance disputes.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/kyrgyz-citizens-to-be-allowed-to-pass-on-e-wallet-funds-to-heirs/)

7. IT tax benefits under scrutiny by the Federal Tax Service: how the tax authority looks for 'business splitting' in corporate groups and revokes IT preferences

(Habr)

The Russian Federal Tax Service *(FNS)* has intensified its scrutiny of IT companies established within larger corporate holding groups. The primary focus is uncovering artificial "business fragmentation" *(under **Article 54.1 of the Russian Tax Code**)* designed solely to exploit reduced insurance premiums for accredited IT entities *(7.6% instead of 30%)*. Tax inspectors are systematically targeting companies that lack external revenue, outsource the majority of their coding to subcontractors, do not hold intellectual property rights to the software they develop, or operate without independent infrastructure and decision-making authority. **If the FNS proves a company was spun off without a legitimate business purpose other than tax evasion, they retroactively cancel the IT benefits, demanding back taxes at the 30% rate alongside significant penalties** *(20–40% of the arrears).* However, legal precedents, such as the successful defense by Demis Group, show that businesses can protect their IT tax benefits if they can prove a distinct economic purpose, maintain separate accounting, justify their pricing, and demand technical expertise from the FNS during disputes.

The Russian tax authorities are actively closing the loophole of creating "shell" IT departments to claim lucrative state tax breaks. To safely utilize IT tax incentives moving forward, corporate groups must ensure that their spun-off tech subsidiaries are genuinely independent entities that possess their own infrastructure, develop proprietary products with in-house staff, and ideally generate revenue from the external market rather than exclusively serving their parent company.

(Read full article at https://habr.com/ru/articles/1003516/)

8. U.S. sanctions Uzbek citizen over alleged cybercrime links

(The Times of Central Asia)

On February 26, 2026, the U.S. Department of the Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control *(OFAC)* sanctioned an Uzbek citizen, Azizjon Mamashoyev *(born 1987)*, **for alleged involvement in cybercrime activities linked to Russian actors**. Issued under the Ukraine-/Russia-Related Sanctions Regulations and the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act *(CAATSA)*, the sanctions designate Mamashoyev for his connection to suspected cybercriminal Sergey Zelenyuk. Additionally, OFAC designated Advance Security Solutions, a computer programming company established in 2025 with operations in both Dubai and Tashkent, due to its connections to Mamashoyev and potential secondary sanction risks. Consequently, their assets within U.S. jurisdiction are frozen, and U.S. persons are prohibited from engaging in transactions with them.

The action by the U.S. Treasury highlights an ongoing, targeted crackdown on international cybercrime networks operating on the periphery of the Russian sphere of influence. By aggressively sanctioning individuals and shell companies operating out of Central Asia and the Middle East, the U.S. aims to sever the financial and operational lifelines of proxy actors who facilitate malicious, state-linked cyber threats under the guise of legitimate tech businesses.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/u-s-sanctions-uzbek-citizen-over-alleged-cybercrime-links/?utm_source)

9. Armenia's Tech Boom

(Los Angeles Times)

Armenia's technology sector is experiencing significant growth, now contributing over 7% to the national GDP and employing more than 50,000 engineers. Driven by the Ministry of High-Tech Industry under Minister **Mkhitar Hayrapetyan**, the government has enacted a seven-year legislative program offering aggressive tax incentives, including up to 60% income tax cashback for job creation and 50% for staff training, to transition the country from a "code-writing" outsourcing destination to a true hub for designing and exporting high-tech products. Strategic initiatives include the "Engineering City" and an upcoming $ 50 million "Factory City" designed to attract multinational manufacturing in electronics and robotics. Furthermore, a recent U.S.–Armenia memorandum on AI and semiconductors, combined with strong investments from the diaspora *(such as the presence of Synopsys Armenia and Synergy International Systems)*, is anchoring the country as a regional AI and R&D powerhouse.

Armenia is successfully executing a deliberate, state-backed economic pivot to overcome its geographic and resource limitations. By aggressively incentivizing tech

investments, leveraging the wealth and expertise of its global diaspora, and building physical infrastructure like Factory City to bridge the gap between **software engineering** and **hardware manufacturing**, the country is rapidly transforming itself into a sovereign, globally competitive, and highly specialized technology hub in the Eurasia region.

(Read full article at https://www.latimes.com/impact-reports/story/armenia-tech-sector-growth-2026)

GLOBAL NEWS

10. Senator Jason Bean delivers immediate property tax relief from data center development

(Missouri Senate)

On February 27, 2026, Missouri State Senator Jason Bean introduced Senate Bill 1790, legislation designed to provide immediate property tax relief to residents in communities

where major data centers are constructed. Currently, under the Hancock Amendment, when a large-scale data center adds massive value to a local tax base as "new construction," taxing jurisdictions receive a substantial revenue windfall while existing taxpayers often have to wait at least two years to see any corresponding reduction in their tax rates. Bean's proposal would close this gap by requiring new data center valuations to be immediately included in rollback calculations to maintain revenue neutrality. For example, Senator Bean noted that a proposed $ 6 billion data center in Festus, Missouri, would reduce property taxes by over 80% for all local residents under this new bill.

Senator Bean's legislation aims to correct a structural lag in local tax reassessments that currently benefits government coffers at the expense of residents. By forcing immediate tax rate rollbacks when massive corporate investments like data centers enter a community, the bill ensures that the economic influx translates instantly into substantial, equitable financial relief for local homeowners, farmers, and small businesses, rather than functioning as a delayed government windfall.

(Read full article at https://senate.mo.gov/Media/NewsDetails/2191)

11. DTA signs new 5-year agreement with Microsoft: delivering value and innovation for the Australian Government

(Australian Government, Digital Transformation Agency)

On February 26, 2026, the Digital Transformation Agency *(DTA)* announced it has secured a new five-year Volume Sourcing Agreement *(VSA6)* with Microsoft on behalf of the Australian Government. Set to commence on July 1, 2026, the agreement introduces a standardized contracting framework designed to provide cost certainty through stable

pricing and capped increases for essential ICT products and online services. Additionally, the arrangement enhances legal protections surrounding data governance, security, and liability, while accelerating the Australian Public Service's *(APS)* ability to adopt emerging technologies like artificial intelligence *(AI)*. This move follows a recent review showing that the government's Single Seller Arrangements successfully generated $ 1.6 billion in discounts between 2019 and 2024.

The renewed five-year agreement underscores the Australian Government's strategy of leveraging its massive collective purchasing power to negotiate highly favorable, modernized terms with global tech giants. **By proactively locking in cost controls, fortifying sovereign data protections, and streamlining access to cutting-edge AI tools, the DTA is not only shielding the public sector from volatile global price fluctuations** but also accelerating the comprehensive digital transformation of the country's critical infrastructure.

(Read full article at https://www.dta.gov.au/articles/dta-signs-new-5-year-agreement-microsoft-delivering-value-and-innovation-australian-government)

12. The EBA publishes follow-up report on ICT risk assessment under the Supervisory Review and Evaluation Process

(European Banking Authority)

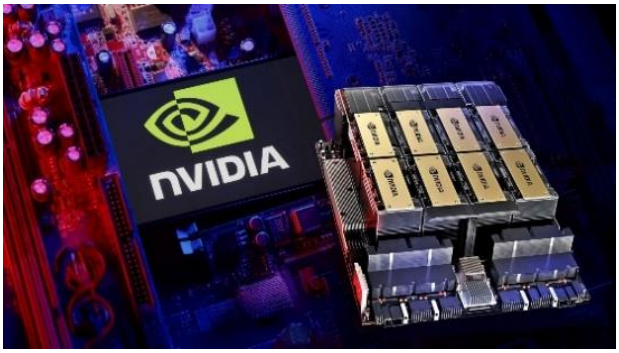
On February 23, 2026, the European Banking Authority *(EBA)* published a follow-up report to its 2022 peer review regarding Information and Communication Technology *(ICT)* risk assessment under the Supervisory Review and Evaluation Process (SREP). The report evaluated the progress made by competent authorities, particularly in light of the application of the Digital Operational Resilience Act *(DORA)* since January 2025. Findings indicate that **EU authorities have made notable improvements in their ICT supervisory capabilities, increasingly utilizing horizontal analyses and consistently applying specific ICT risk sub-categories**. However, the EBA emphasized that further work and sustained investment are still required to achieve fully consistent and effective ICT risk supervision and operational resilience across the European Union.

The EBA's follow-up report highlights a positive trajectory in the EU's financial regulatory environment, largely catalyzed by the implementation of DORA. While national competent authorities have successfully upgraded their baseline ICT risk assessment frameworks and methodologies, the EBA's call for continued investment signals that the rapidly evolving nature of digital risks requires ongoing regulatory harmonization to prevent fragmented supervisory practices across member states.

(Read full article at https://www.eba.europa.eu/publications-and-media/press-releases/eba-publishes-follow-report-ict-risk-assessment-under-supervisory-review-and-evaluation-process#:~:text=It%20assessed%20progress%20in%20light,on%20related%20supervisory%20convergence%20work.)

13. Nvidia H200 sales in China have collapsed – zero chips sold in two months

(Habr)



Despite the Trump administration's December approval of Nvidia H200 exports to China – complete with a 25% U.S. revenue cut – Nvidia's sales there have effectively hit zero. While Chinese tech giants initially ordered millions of units, Beijing intervened by restricting H200 access to niche uses like university labs, favoring domestic procurement instead.

Consequently, Nvidia has excluded Chinese H200 revenue from its Q1 forecasts, with CEO Jensen Huang confirming a total loss of market share. This pivot has fueled a surge in China's domestic sector:

Huawei's Ascend 910B: Zhipu AI recently trained its GLM-5 model using 100,000 Huawei chips, entirely bypassing Nvidia hardware.

Usage Dominance is that Chinese models now occupy four of the top five spots for token consumption on OpenRouter.

Beijing is now mirroring Washington's restrictive tactics to force-start its own chip industry. By blocking American hardware, China has turned initial U.S. sanctions into a catalyst for technological independence, likely locking Nvidia out of its most lucrative market permanently.

(Read full article at https://habr.com/ru/amp/publications/1005268/?utm_source)

14. Facebook owner Meta to buy AI chips from AMD in deal worth up to $ 100 billion

(Yahoo!finance)

Meta has entered into a massive artificial intelligence chip agreement with semiconductor company AMD. The deal centers around a massive 6-gigawatt power deployment of AMD's AI chips, with the total value of the arrangement potentially exceeding $ 100 billion. Notably, the agreement also includes a strategic pathway for Meta to acquire up to a 10% ownership stake in AMD.

This unprecedented $ 100 billion agreement marks a major escalation in the global AI hardware arms race. By securing a 6-gigawatt pipeline of AMD chips and a potential 10% equity stake, Meta is aggressively diversifying its AI infrastructure away from a sole reliance on market-leader Nvidia.

This strategic partnership not only guarantees Meta the massive computational power required to train future AI models but also firmly positions AMD as a top-tier contender in the lucrative AI semiconductor market.

(Read full article at https://finance.yahoo.com/news/facebook-owner-meta-buy-ai-132515249.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com&guccounter=1&guce_referrer=aHR0cHM6Ly9jaGF0Z3B0LmNvbS8&guce_referrer_sig=AQAAAFeDQgvd3XPEGMJwmZBHTt84umSMo0wh6AnJwRcEyS5kpP_NRiWpa9FGMlBkcRM2BpoP3YiCT0td80rbmtjl6DvO0Bl38ebxSulPCXO5B7AO-61j2K-r6Xtx1fMh2X3FNJsu_ndvxG1OiVr5VucKwKl1JZfqcPYC2Xs11usTyfce)

15. Rosewood Initiative launches new East Portland Tech Hub

(The Outlook)

On February 26, 2026, The Rosewood Initiative launched a new Small Business Tech Hub in East Multnomah County, Portland. Funded by an $ 80,000 investment from Comcast *(as a new "Lift Zone")* and the Mt. Hood Cable Regulatory Commission, the hub is designed to support local entrepreneurs and home-based businesses that lack access to professional resources. The facility provides high-speed internet, computers, business software, and a professional photo studio during drop-in hours. In addition to physical technology access, the hub offers skill-building workshops on digital marketing, bookkeeping, and tech skills, as well as one-on-one support by matching business owners with liaisons from Prosper Portland.

New Tech Hub represents a targeted, community-level intervention aimed at bridging the digital divide for small and home-based businesses in East Portland. By providing localized, **free or low-cost access to professional-grade technology and vital business training, the initiative directly tackles the structural barriers that hinder economic equity**, empowering local entrepreneurs to scale their operations and compete more effectively in the digital economy.

ANALYSIS

16. From Smart Cities to AI Education: Kazakhstan's 2026 digitalization projects

(The Astana Times)

Kazakhstan has begun implementing a plan for the Year of Digitalization and Artificial Intelligence, aimed at modernizing public administration, expanding AI education, strengthening cybersecurity and accelerating the country's transition to a new digital economy in 2026.

The action plan, approved by Prime Minister Olzhas Bektenov, includes eight priority blocks and ten key initiatives. The official launch is scheduled for March at the Alem.Ai building.

The program covers strategic planning, regulatory reform, human capital development, GovTech transformation, cybersecurity, sectoral digitalization, smart city development and the formation of a new digital economy.

As part of this block, a strategy called **Digital Qazaqstan** is planned, along with the development of tax and other support measures for national IT companies. It is also planned to adopt no more than 90% of the key laws in digitalization, AI, data, cybersecurity, telecommunications and digital assets.

Under the **AI-Sana initiative**, the AI education project will be expanded across all levels, including schools, universities and adult retraining and professional development programs. For secondary education, the plan includes the Day of AI Qazaqstan event and the opening of TUMO Centers. Overall, the project aims to reach at least 450,000 students and teachers to develop their digital and AI skills.

A new stage of AI University and the expansion of the AI school, Tomorrow School, in regions for training AI specialists, is set to begin. Additionally, the AI Governance 500 program will be launched to prepare digital leaders for the public and quasi-public sectors.

The **AI Qyzmet** is being developed for government employees, and a new program called AI Corporate will teach company staff how to delegate routine tasks to AI.

GovTech: a digital model of public administration block focuses on the transition of government agencies to the GovTech digital model. Key priorities include creating a digital workplace for civil servants, expanding eGov capabilities *(including eGov Business)*, developing Social Wallet services and implementing AI on the National AI Platform.

The plan includes providing at least 80% of civil servants with **Gov Workspace** digital workstations, delivering at least 50 government services powered by AI, and migrating at least 30% of government information systems to the QazTech platform. Internet access will also be expanded on trains, planes, at tourist attractions and at border crossings via Direct to Cell satellite communications. This is expected to improve the quality of digital government services for citizens and businesses by at least 75%.

Strengthening cybersecurity and protecting personal data are key priorities of this block. Planned measures include enhancing information security systems, auditing government IT systems, addressing vulnerabilities and implementing mandatory information security protocols. Priority will also be given to migrating government information systems to a new government data processing center.

Sectoral digitalization: digital transformation will extend across energy, agriculture, logistics, construction and finance. Planned measures include AI integration in energy management, digitization of 90% of geological data, AI-based agricultural monitoring to boost yields by 10%, digital logistics platforms and broader adoption of Building Information Modeling *(BIM)* technology in construction projects.

This block focuses on the digital development of cities and regions. This year, plans include building fiber-optic communication lines *(FOCL)* in villages, providing mobile internet along highways and expanding 5G coverage in 20 cities.

Public service centers will be transformed into digital offices with self-service areas. Additionally, a Smart City project is planned for Astana, along with the expansion of IT hubs.

The projected outcomes are high-speed internet access for 99% of citizens, 100% 5G coverage in 20 major cities, an annual increase in the urban comfort index by 15% or more, and the transformation of at least 20 public service centers into digital offices with self-service areas.

Kazakhstan's 2026 digitalization agenda represents an aggressive, holistic push to embed artificial intelligence and advanced digital infrastructure into the core of its public and private sectors. By strategically coupling heavy physical infrastructure investments, such as nationwide 5G and satellite internet, with comprehensive human capital development and regulatory overhaul, the government is moving beyond surface-level tech adoption. Instead, it is actively re-engineering its workforce and governance models to secure a competitive, sovereign edge in the global AI economy.

(Read full article at https://astanatimes.com/2026/02/from-smart-cities-to-ai-education-kazakhstans-2026-digitalization-projects/)

17. Digital inequality in Central Asia: who is winning the AI race in finance?

(The Times of Central Asia)

A recent report by the National Bank of Kazakhstan highlights a deepening digital divide across Central Asia's financial sector, driven by starkly divergent artificial intelligence strategies. Rather than a unified regional approach, these nations are fracturing along lines of technological sovereignty versus global integration.

Kazakhstan has established itself as the undisputed regional leader. Moving well beyond pilot programs, its financial institutions are actively deploying AI for hyper-personalized marketing and complex product development. Crucially, to mitigate geopolitical risks and ensure total data security, Astana is prioritizing costly, sovereign data centers over foreign cloud providers, positioning the state as the primary infrastructure architect.

In contrast, Uzbekistan is rapidly narrowing the technological gap through a partnership-driven model. Acknowledging its need for foundational infrastructure, Tashkent is collaborating with global tech giants like Huawei to build out its physical servers and cloud capacity, while simultaneously investing heavily in academic development to support future growth.

Meanwhile, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan remain severely restricted despite drafting ambitious long-term policy frameworks. Their financial markets, dominated by cautious microfinance organizations, face a profound human capital crisis. As a result, nearly half of

their AI-related investments are absorbed by basic staff retraining and the search for rudimentary use cases, illustrating a struggle for strategic maturity rather than advanced technological deployment.

AI in Central Asian finance has evolved from a theoretical upgrade into a definitive competitive threshold. While the region's economic heavyweights scale AI to capture market share and assert regulatory control, smaller nations are still battling fundamental infrastructure and talent deficits just to enter the race.

(Read full article at https://timesca.com/digital-inequality-in-central-asia-who-is-winning-the-ai-race-in-finance/)

18. South Africa's budget speech unveils bold moves on data infrastructure and tax incentives

(BDO)

South Africa's latest Budget Speech marks a decisive pivot from traditional resource reliance toward a technology-driven economic framework. Central to this vision is the official classification of data centers as critical national infrastructure, placing them on the same strategic tier as power grids and transport networks. This regulatory upgrade is designed to fast-track zoning and operational approvals, serving as a powerful magnet for global hyper-scalers like AWS and Microsoft to firmly anchor Africa's cloud capacity within South Africa.

Complementing this physical infrastructure push are aggressive tax reforms engineered to stimulate both domestic innovation and foreign investment. The expansion of the Research and Development *(R&D)* tax incentive is particularly notable, as it now allows businesses to claim deductions for internal software and AI development, such as bespoke ERPs, logistics engines, and fintech tools. This corrects a historical bias that only rewarded externally commercialized products, directly incentivizing legacy sectors like mining and banking to digitize their operations. Furthermore, the government is enhancing its appeal to foreign direct investment by relaxing the strict related-party transaction rules required to access the 15% corporate tax rate in Special Economic Zones *(SEZs)*. By lowering these bureaucratic barriers, South Africa is making it significantly easier for multinational tech conglomerates to establish regional headquarters.

To ensure this macroeconomic tech growth does not outpace domestic spatial equity, the government is simultaneously refocusing Urban Development Zone *(UDZ)* tax incentives strictly toward affordable housing near essential services. However, the ultimate success of this ambitious digital roadmap hinges on overcoming severe structural risks. The massive power demands of data centers will heavily test the stability of the national energy grid, making renewable integration critical. Additionally, **the sudden corporate push for AI and software innovation threatens to expose a massive skills deficit, which could**

bottleneck growth unless countered by rapid local upskilling or streamlined highly-skilled visa programs.

South Africa is strategically pivoting its economic framework to prioritize and aggressively incentivize digital transformation and technological infrastructure. By officially classifying data centers as critical national infrastructure, expanding R&D tax benefits to cover internal corporate software and AI development, and relaxing previously restrictive tax rules in Special Economic Zones, the government is actively working to stimulate local corporate innovation and attract significant foreign direct investment in the tech sector.

(Read full article at https://www.bdo.co.za/en-za/insights/2026/budget-speech/south-africa%E2%80%99s-budget-speech-unveils-bold-moves-on-data-infrastructure-and-tax-incentives#:~:text=These%20efforts%20aim%20to%20position,and%20development%20(R%26D)%20activity)

Events calendar for IT PARK UZBEKISTAN, RESIDENTS OF IT PARK UZBEKISTAN and MINISTRY OF DIGITAL TECHNOLOGIES – *(March 2026)*

IT PARK UZBEKISTAN					
Date	**Event name**	**Description**	**Location**	**Event holder**	**Official Website**
Mar 02-06	Humanitarian Networks & Partnerships Week	IT Park can pitch its "Tech for Good" and inclusive sourcing capabilities to UN/NGO stakeholders.	Geneva *(Online)*	UNDP / UN	undp.org
Mar 03	Multi-Channel E-Commerce Strategies	Regional summit to discover logistics and retail companies in need of e-commerce software solutions.	Osh, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com
Mar 03	Global Crises & Business Adaptation Strategies	Provides insights into how global enterprises are shifting to resilient offshore hubs like Uzbekistan.	Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com
Mar 04	Verification of Belarusian goods on Ozon	Trade webinar. IT Park can observe cross-border e-commerce operations to advise its resident marketplace developers.	Minsk *(Online)*	BelCCI	cci.by
Mar 04	Emerging Manager Power Hour	Exclusive NVCA session on how venture capital firms gain exposure; useful for IT Park Ventures strategy.	USA *(Online)*	NVCA / Venture Forward	nvca.org
Mar 16	Exploration of applied competencies	Regional integration workshop with EU universities to bridge knowledge gaps in the Central Asian talent pool.	Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Digitech	digitech.kg
Mar 17	Sourcing Spotlight on India	BME webinar exploring global procurement corridors, helping IT Park map competition and partnership routes.	Germany *(Online)*	BME Matchmaking	bmematchmaking.com

Mar 17-19	Union of Industrialists & Entrepreneurs Expo	Strategic exhibition in Ashgabat. IT Park can promote its "Local2Global" expansion initiatives to Turkmen businesses.	Ashgabat, Turkmenistan *(Offline)*	Chamber of Commerce	turkmenistaninfo.gov.tm
Mar 23-26	Kube Con 2026	Cloud Native flagship event. IT Park infrastructure managers can explore edge-computing tech for local data centers.	Amsterdam *(Online)*	CNCF	nebius.com
Mar 24	Sourcing Social: Service Provider User Group	GSA UK session. IT Park leadership engages with UK buyers to shape the "Emerging Locations" outsourcing narrative.	UK *(Online)*	GSA UK	gsa-uk.com
Mar 24-25	Free CX Network Webinar Series	Valuable strategic intelligence on how global brands are shifting their customer experience outsourcing budgets.	Online	CX Network	cxnetwork.com
Mar 25-27	AgroWorld Uzbekistan 2026	Large domestic expo. IT Park uses this to connect resident AgTech startups with traditional agricultural conglomerates.	Tashkent, Uzbekistan *(Offline)*	Iteca Exhibitions	iteca.uz
Mar 26	Turkmenistan-EU Business Forum 2026	High-level trade forum. IT Park can observe EU digital trade policies extending into the Caspian/Central Asian corridor.	Ashgabat, Turkmenistan *(Offline)*	Int'l Trade Centre	intracen.org
RESIDENTS OF IT PARK UZBEKISTAN					
Date	**Event name**	**Description**	**Location**	**Event holder**	**Official Website**
Mar 03	Founder's Guide to AI	A Founder Institute session on converting data into business value, ideal for early-stage IT Park startups.	USA *(Online)*	Founder Institute	fi.co

Mar 03	Azure Virtual Training: Data Fundamentals	Teaches core data concepts and platforms like Databricks and Microsoft Fabric for unified analytics.	Online	Microsoft Azure	microsoft.com/events
Mar 03	Azure Virtual Training: Migrate and Secure	Strategies to protect Azure IaaS workloads and execute scalable migrations for enterprise clients.	Online	Microsoft Azure	microsoft.com/events
Mar 03	AI-Powered Modernization	Google Cloud session on transitioning legacy code to modern architectures using AI.	Online	Google Cloud OnAir	cloudonair.withgoogle.com
Mar 04	DeveloperWeek Global 2026	The virtual edition of the massive developer conference, covering DevEx, APIs, and Web3.	Online	DevNetwork	developerweek.com
Mar 04	Grounding AI Agents with Search/Maps	A Google lab on building real-world aware AI applications by grounding Gemini models.	Online	Google Cloud OnAir	cloudonair.withgoogle.com
Mar 05	The AI-Powered Adversary	Uncovers LLM-enabled cyber-attack tactics, crucial for resident cybersecurity firms.	Online	Google Cloud	cloud.google.com
Mar 05	Serverless Data Science	Explores seamless AI workflows with Spark and BigQuery to minimize infrastructure costs.	Online	Google Cloud	cloudonair.withgoogle.com
Mar 06	Int'l Conf on Blockchain and Cryptocurrency	Technical conference useful for IT Park's Web3 and decentralized finance *(DeFi)* startups.	Dushanbe, Tajikistan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferenceineurope.org
Mar 06-08	Techstars Startup Weekend Vancouver	Virtual access hackathon guiding founders through rapid	Vancouver, Canada *(Online)*	Techstars	techstars.com

		prototyping and MVP launches.			
Mar 07	Int'l Conf on Artificial Intelligence and Robotics	Explores algorithmic modeling, machine learning, and hardware integration.	Dushanbe, Tajikistan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferenceineurope.org
Mar 10	Production-Ready Agents	A Google Cloud workshop on scaling autonomous AI agents using MCP servers.	Online	Google Cloud	cloudonair.withgoogle.com
Mar 10	Science, Technology, Engineering and Management	A cross-disciplinary forum for discovering applied tech solutions in the Caucasus market.	Baku, Azerbaijan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	allconferencealert.com
Mar 11	AI Runs on Open Source	Linux Foundation session on leveraging open-source tools for robust AI architectures.	Online	Linux Foundation	linuxfoundation.org
Mar 11	Coordinating Secure GPU-Accelerated Agents	Microsoft Reactor lab covering Foundry Control Plane orchestration for advanced Azure AI.	Online	Microsoft Reactor	developer.microsoft.com
Mar 11	Blockchain & Cybersecurity in Big Data	Explores cryptography in high-volume data environments, essential for fintech residents.	Osh, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com
Mar 12	Microsoft Azure Summit: Migrate with Agentic AI	Explores reducing operational complexity by deploying agentic solutions during cloud migrations.	Online	Microsoft	microsoft.com/events
Mar 17	Context Engineering for Self-Healing AI SRE	Advanced SRE methodologies utilizing AI to auto-correct infrastructure faults.	Online	Linux Foundation	linuxfoundation.org
Mar 18	Practical Approaches to Interoperable Blockchain	Discusses cross-chain compatibility and smart contract engineering.	Online	Linux Foundation	linuxfoundation.org

Mar 19	Build Agentic AI Solutions (Session 1)	Microsoft training on Semantic Kernel Agent Framework and Azure AI Foundry.	Online	Microsoft	microsoft.com/events
Mar 19	Predictive Analytics & ML Models	Academic and applied deep dive into predictive data modeling algorithms.	Osh, Kyrgyzstan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com
Mar 21	World Congress on IT and Computer Science	A broad technical congress allowing developers to benchmark against global engineering standards.	Brest, Belarus *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferenceineurope.org
Mar 22	Build Agentic AI Solutions (Session 2)	Second session for developers to master custom AI agent generation on Azure.	Online	Microsoft	microsoft.com/events
Mar 23	Blockchain and AI in International Business	AIB webinar investigating how these technologies are applied practically by global firms.	Online	AIB	aib.world
Mar 24	What's New: Connected ERP for Private Capital	Carta webinar analyzing backend financial tech systems and SaaS tools for venture capital.	Online	Carta	carta.com
Mar 25	Is your startup ready for fundraising?	Swiss Startup Association webinar teaching founders how to use AI to improve pitch metrics.	Online	Swiss Startup Assoc	swissstartupassociation.ch
Mar 26	betterCode() Clean Architecture 2026	Intensive software engineering conference focusing on maintainable, scalable codebases.	Online	IT Community	dev.events
Mar 26-27	Node Congress	A massive virtual gathering for backend developers building scalable apps with Node.js.	Online	IT Community	dev.events
Mar 27	Smart Manufacturing	Niche event for residents building	Baku, Azerbaijan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	internationalconferencealerts.com

	Systems using Blockchain	industrial IoT and supply chain tracking software.			
MINISTRY OF DIGITAL TECHNOLOGIES					
Date	**Event name**	**Description**	**Location**	**Event holder**	**Official Website**
Mar 02-04	OECD Financial Markets Week Spring 2026	Focuses on international financial policies. Essential for the Ministry to benchmark digital finance and tech investment frameworks.	Paris, France *(Online)*	OECD	oecd.org
Mar 03	Int'l Conf on Spatial Computing and Cloud GIS	Explores cloud-based geographic information systems, crucial for updating Uzbekistan's digital land registry and urban planning.	Bukhara, Uzbekistan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
Mar 04	2026 OECD Competition Open Day	Global summit exploring regulatory frameworks for digital markets and AI competitiveness.	Paris, France *(Online)*	OECD	oecd.org
Mar 04	AI Without Blind Spots: Observability Strategies	GovTech webinar on deploying AI in public sector IT securely and transparently.	*USA (*Online*)*	GovTech / e.Republic	webinars.govtech.com
Mar 05	AI in Action: Modernizing Data Governance	Workshop equipping government officials with AI tools to streamline eDiscovery, FOIA, and public records management.	*USA (*Online*)*	Digital Government Institute	digitalgovernment.com
Mar 10	Flexible Tech Strategies for Uncertain Terrain	A session for government leaders on agile IT procurement and maintaining resilient digital services.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	webinars.govtech.com
Mar 11	Rebuilding from Disaster with Technology	Examines how digital tools assess damage and coordinate state responses during natural crises.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	webinars.govtech.com

Mar 12	ENISA Cybersecurity Standardisation Conference	Focuses on the European AI Act and Data Act, vital for the Ministry aligning Uzbek cyber laws with EU standards.	Brussels, Belgium *(Hybrid)*	ENISA	enisa.europa.eu
Mar 12	Industry Insider – California Member Briefing	Briefing on state-level digital modernization projects, offering blueprints for Uzbekistan's e-Gov systems.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	events.govtech.com
Mar 19	Georgia Public Sector Cybersecurity Summit	Interactive sessions on building cyber-resilient organizations and protecting state data.	Atlanta, USA *(Offline)*	GovTech	events.govtech.com
Mar 19	Int'l Conf on GIS in Disaster Management	Discusses tech-driven risk reduction, highly relevant to the Ministry's Smart Nation initiatives.	Tashkent, Uzbekistan *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
Mar 19	Spatial Data Infrastructure and Policy	Armenian summit on data policy, beneficial for harmonizing Central Asian data exchange systems.	Gyumri, Armenia *(Hybrid)*	Conference Alerts	conferencealerts.co.in
Mar 25	Fight Fraud, Waste and Abuse with AI	GovTech webinar demonstrating AI applications for auditing and securing public funds.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	webinars.govtech.com
Mar 25-26	Government Efficiency Summit 2026	Explores the intersection of automation, AI, and streamlined government operations.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	events.govtech.com
Mar 25	North Carolina AI and Cybersecurity Symposium	Investigates policy overlaps between AI adoption and national security protocols.	Raleigh, USA *(Offline)*	GovTech	events.govtech.com
Mar 25-26	Tashkent Water Week 2026	A sector-specific event where the Ministry can explore IoT and digital	Tashkent, Uzbekistan *(Offline)*	Iteca Exhibitions	iteca.uz

		monitoring for water resource management.			
Mar 26	Eligibility Decisions You Can Defend	Explores how AI-assisted systems improve accuracy and oversight in citizen service determinations.	USA *(Online)*	GovTech	webinars.govtech.com
Mar 26	Securing the Cyber/Software Supply Chain	Virtual workshop equipping government officials to safeguard IT procurement and software assets.	USA *(Online)*	Digital Government Institute	digitalgovernment.com